A COMPANION TO

HANDWRITING WORTH SIGNING

Printable Pack

Guide sheets, logs and every practice page of the book



Emma R. Thistlewood

INSIDE

Guide sheets

- Practice-size guide sheet 2
- Upright guide sheet, for left-handed and upright writers 3
- Two-thirds guide sheet, for cards and tags 4
- Everyday-size sheet 5

Logs and plan

- Speed ladder log 6
- Before and after sample 7
- Four-week plan 8

From the book

- All 33 practice pages, Chapters 2 to 11, at full size 10

HOW TO USE IT

- Slip a guide sheet under a plain sheet: the lines show through and the page stays clean.

Print as often as you like, for your own practice. Print at 100% (Actual size) on Letter paper.
Plain 20 to 24 lb copy paper is fine; use 32 lb or marker paper for the brush pen.

Practice-size guide sheet

Small letters 3/8 in. For every practice page of the book, for the warm-up and for the brush pen.



Upright guide sheet

The same lines with upright guides, for left-handed and upright writers (Chapters 1 and 6).

Two-thirds guide sheet

Small letters 1/4 in, the size for names on cards, tags and place cards (Chapter 11).



GUIDE SHEETS

Everyday-size sheet

Wide-ruled lines 11/32 in apart with light slant lines, for notes at everyday size (Chapter 7).

LOGS AND PLAN

Speed ladder log

One row for each ladder (Chapter 7). Speed: Slow, Medium or Normal.

Date	Speed	Seconds	What broke first	Fixed?

Before and after sample

Write the sentence of the Introduction on the four lines, at your normal speed, then sign and date it.

Thank you for the lovely flowers; they brightened the whole week.

Signature _____ Date _____

Signature _____ Date _____

LOGS AND PLAN

Four-week plan

The plan of Chapter 7. Tick a box for each session; repeat a week until its check passes.

Week 1

warm-up 5 min, one letter family 5, joins slow 5, ladder line slow and medium 5

☐ Day 1 ☐ Day 2 ☐ Day 3 ☐ Day 4 ☐ Day 5 ☐ Day 6

Check passed on: _____

Week 2

warm-up 5, family that broke first 4, joins slow to medium 4, short notes at medium speed 6

☐ Day 1 ☐ Day 2 ☐ Day 3 ☐ Day 4 ☐ Day 5 ☐ Day 6

Check passed on: _____

Week 3

warm-up 5, family that broke first 3, joins medium 3, a recipe, list or poem at normal speed 7

☐ Day 1 ☐ Day 2 ☐ Day 3 ☐ Day 4 ☐ Day 5 ☐ Day 6

Check passed on: _____

Week 4

warm-up 5, weakest family 2, joins medium to normal 3, real notes at normal speed 10

☐ Day 1 ☐ Day 2 ☐ Day 3 ☐ Day 4 ☐ Day 5 ☐ Day 6

Check passed on: _____

FROM THE BOOK

Practice pages from the book

The practice pages of Chapters 2 to 11, at full size, with the book page number at the top of each one.

Ch 2 — Writing from the Arm

Book page 20

Ch 3 — The Everyday Alphabet, Family by Family

Book pages 25, 27, 29, 31, 33, 34

Ch 4 — Joining Without Losing Legibility

Book pages 39, 42

Ch 5 — Capitals, Numbers and a Signature Worth Signing

Book pages 45, 47, 49, 51

Ch 6 — Make It Your Own

Book pages 54, 56

Ch 7 — Keeping It at Real Speed

Book pages 60, 62

Ch 8 — The Bridge to Your Display Hand

Book pages 69, 70

Ch 9 — Brush Pen Basics

Book pages 74, 76, 78

Ch 10 — The Brush Alphabet

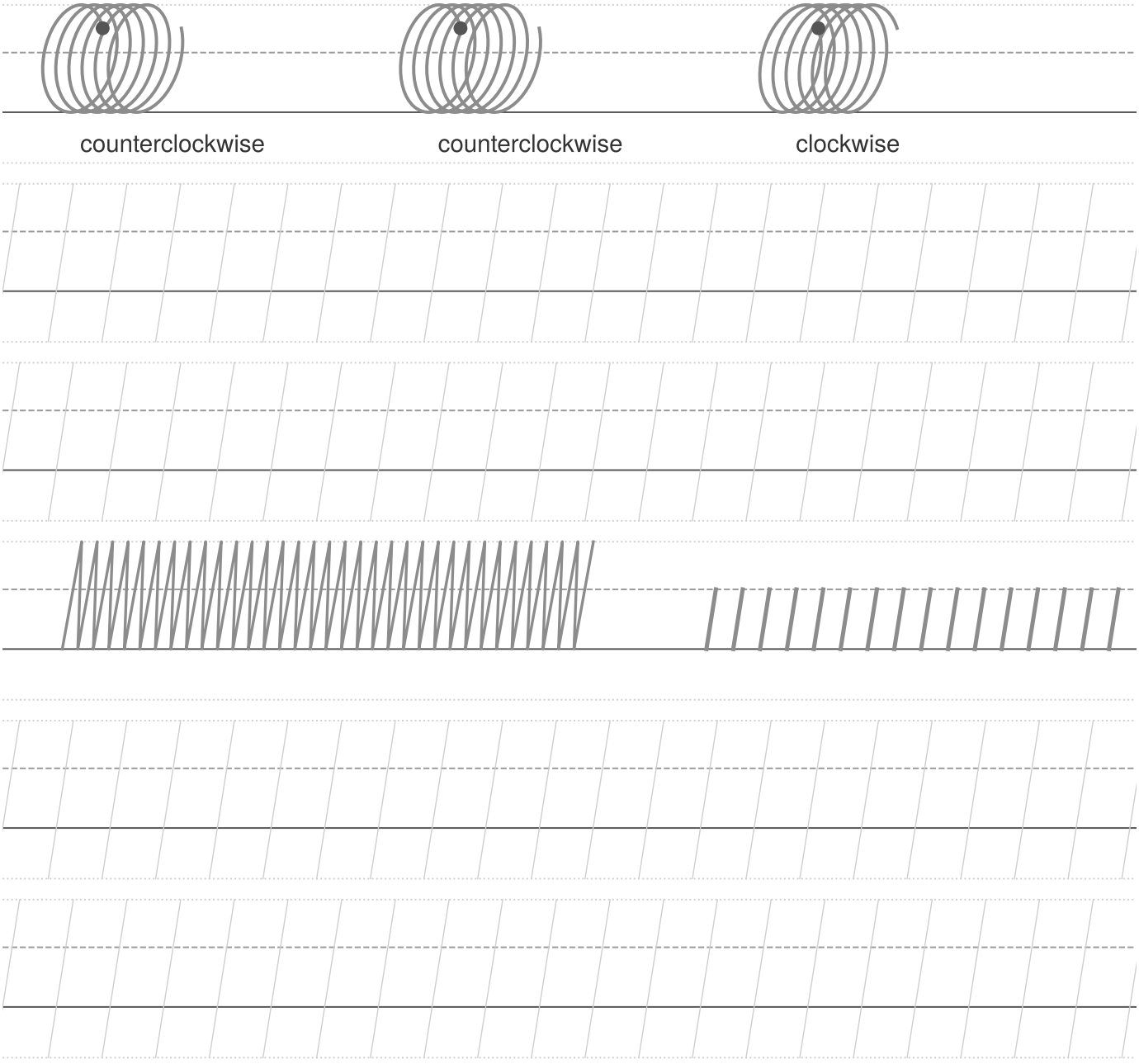
Book pages 81, 83, 85, 87, 89, 91, 93, 94

Ch 11 — Pages Worth Giving

Book pages 97, 100, 102

Practice: ovals, push-pulls and lines

The page has two blocks, ovals and then lines. Each starts with grey samples to copy, not trace. Top block: counterclockwise ovals on the first empty line, six turns as in the samples, ten once your hand is comfortable, clockwise on the second. Lower block: push-pulls on the first, straight lines on the second. One or two groups per line is enough. Work slowly and lightly, and stop if your hand tires or aches; open and close it gently, as in Chapter 1, before you go on. If you are left-handed, use the grey samples as a guide to size and spacing, then follow your own even lean. More practice sheets for these drills are in the printable pack (QR code in the Introduction).



Practice: the oval family

Trace each grey row, then copy it once on an empty row; use the last rows for the letters you find hardest. One or two empty rows are enough on a tired day. Slow and even beats fast and pretty. When a letter looks wrong, compare it with the check on the facing page before you write the next one. The other practice pages in this chapter work the same way.



Practice: the hill family

Trace each grey row, then copy it once on an empty row.



Practice: the loop family

Trace each grey row, then copy it once on an empty row.



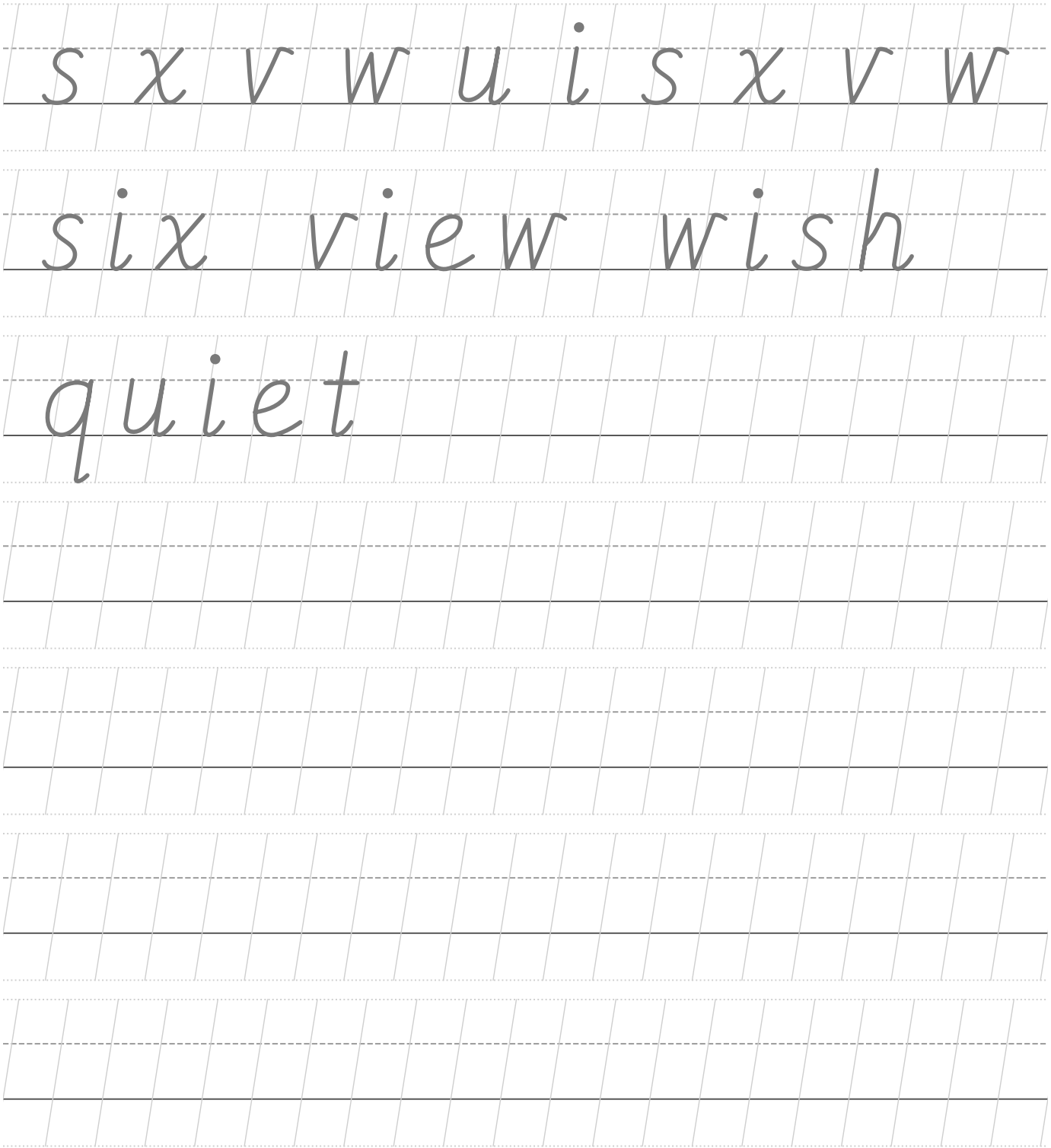
Practice: letters with tails

Trace each grey row, then copy it once on an empty row.



Practice: the troublemakers

Trace each grey row, then copy it once on an empty row.



Practice lines on real words

Now put all the families together on things you might actually write: a thank-you note, a recipe, a line from an Emily Dickinson poem, a card. Capitals have their own chapter, so for now write everything in lowercase, with a small space between the letters and a wider space between words. On the facing page the four lines come in that order; the third is the opening of Dickinson's "Hope is the thing with feathers." Trace each grey line once at your slowest comfortable speed, then write it again on the empty line below it.

When a word looks uneven, find the one letter that broke the pattern, usually an oval that leans the wrong way or stands upright, or an arch that started too low, and practice that letter's family for a few lines before you come back to the word. More sheets for every family, and blank guide sheets for your own words, are in the printable pack (QR code in the Introduction).

Your progress

Date, your best line today, and the one thing to fix next time.

Date _____

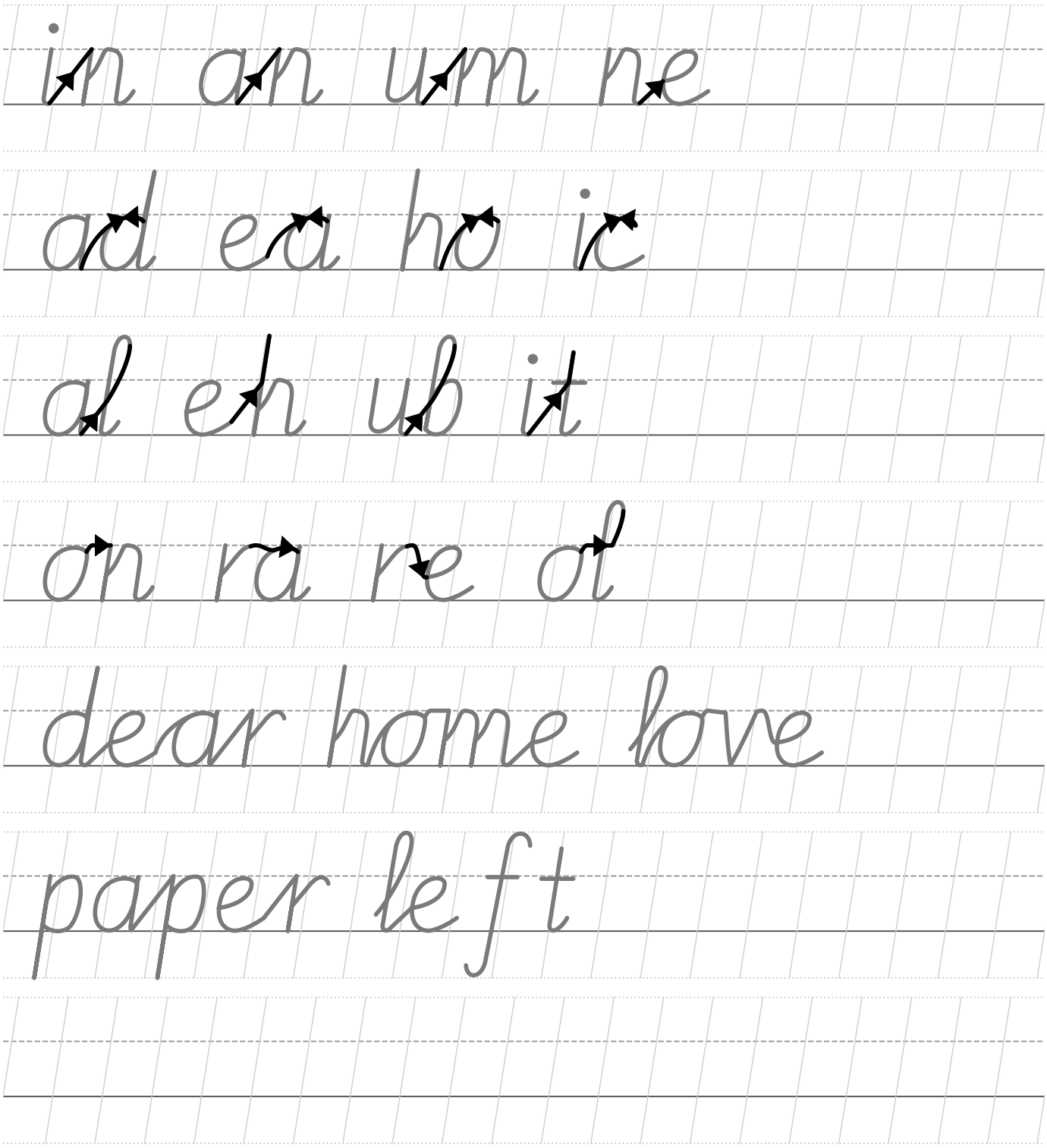
Best line today

Next time: _____

Write a word you write often, three times on each row.

Practice: pairs and short words

Trace each grey pair, following the black join, then copy the two pairs you find hardest in the space at the end of the line. Write each pair as one movement and lift only to dot or cross. On lines 5 and 6, trace the words, write left again at the end of line 6, and write dear home love on line 7. Stop when your hand tires: open and close it gently, and come back to the page in another session.



Practice: whole lines

Trace each grey line once at your slowest comfortable speed, then write it on the empty line below, and do the arm's-length check on your own lines. If your hand is tired, leave this page for another session. Blank guide sheets for your own sentences are in the printable pack (QR code in the Introduction).

thank you for dinner

key under the blue pot

fold in the cream

Write a sentence of your own on these rows with the joins of this chapter.

Practice: capitals, group by group

Trace each grey group, then copy it once on the rest of the line, following the start dots and stroke order of Figure 5.1, two pages back. On line 6, trace the names with a lift after each capital, then write a first name you use often after them, joining from its capital if Figure 5.2 allows. Stop when your hand tires.



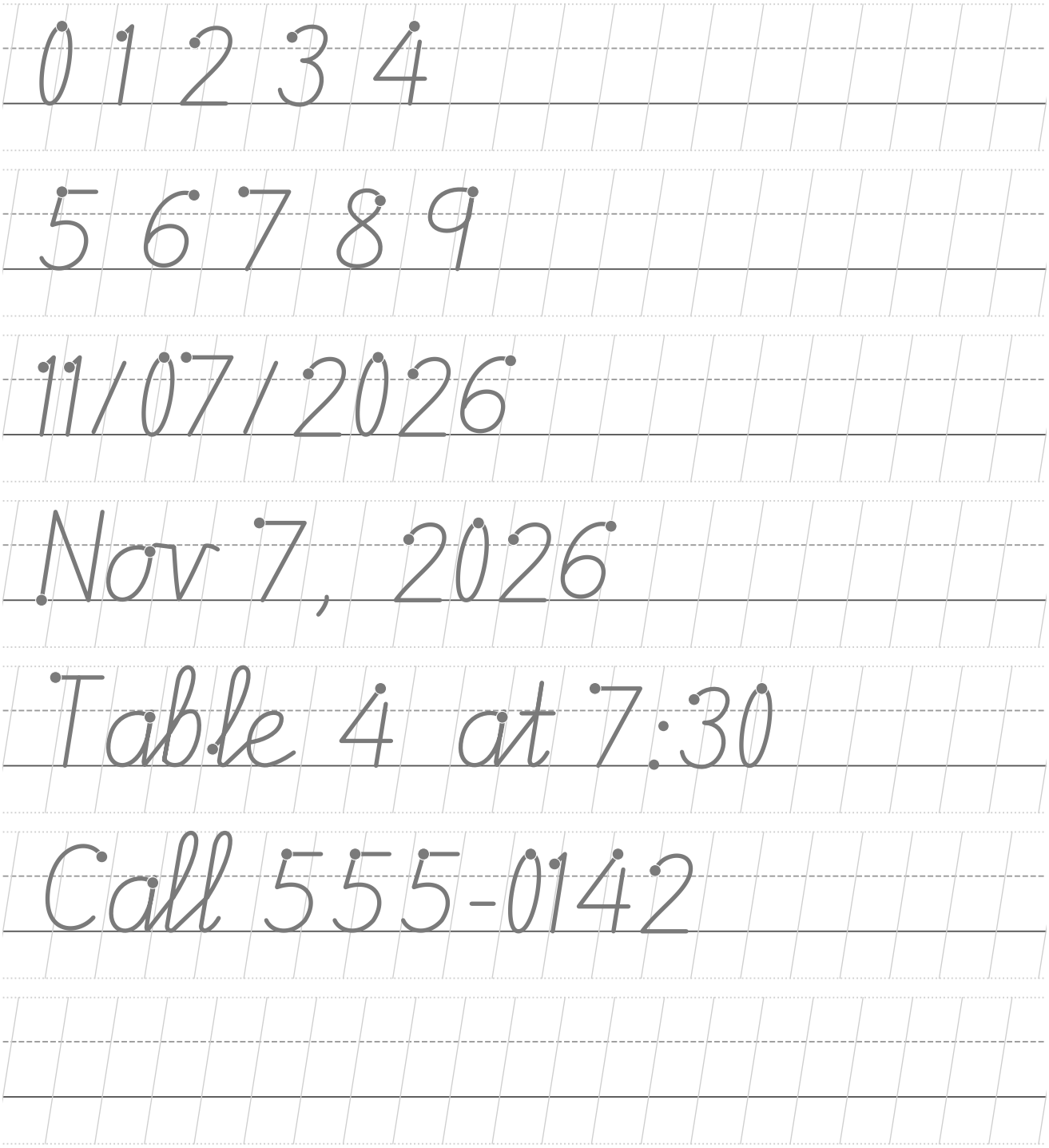
What to look at

Check these points on your capitals:

- ☐ Every capital leans with your lowercase and stops below the tops of l, d and h.
- ☐ O is round, and the bowls of B, D, P and R close at the stem.
- ☐ I has its two short bars.
- ☐ The gap after a capital is no wider than the other letter gaps.

Practice: numbers and dates

Trace each grey line. On lines 1 and 2, copy it on the rest of the line; on line 3, write today's date in numbers after the model. Lines 4 to 6 are for tracing only. On line 7, write today's date with the month as a short word, as on line 4, then your ZIP Code. Stop when your hand tires; the page will wait.



Practice: your signature

1. Trace each grey version of the sample name on the first three lines, then try the same approach with your own name on the rest of the line, or on a guide sheet if it does not fit.
2. On the blank guide line, write the version you like best twice, changing one decision the second time (once, if it is long; use a guide sheet for more tries).
3. Rest your hand, then sign five times on the plain lines, a little smaller than practice size, with small letters about 1/4 inch tall, at a speed that keeps all five the same, with each tail clear of the line below. Stop when your hand tires.



Five times

Signature _____

Signature _____

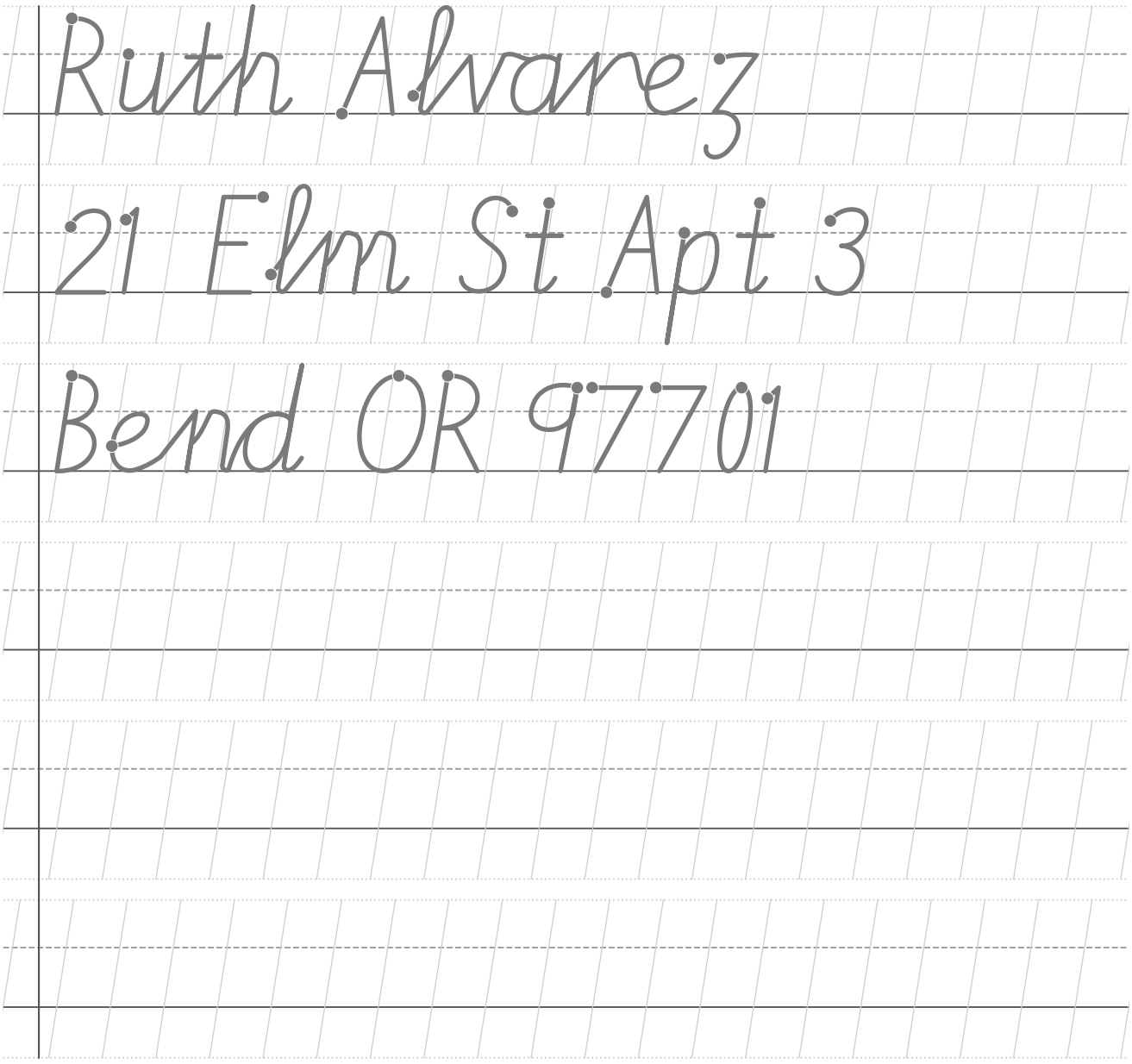
Signature _____

Signature _____

Signature _____

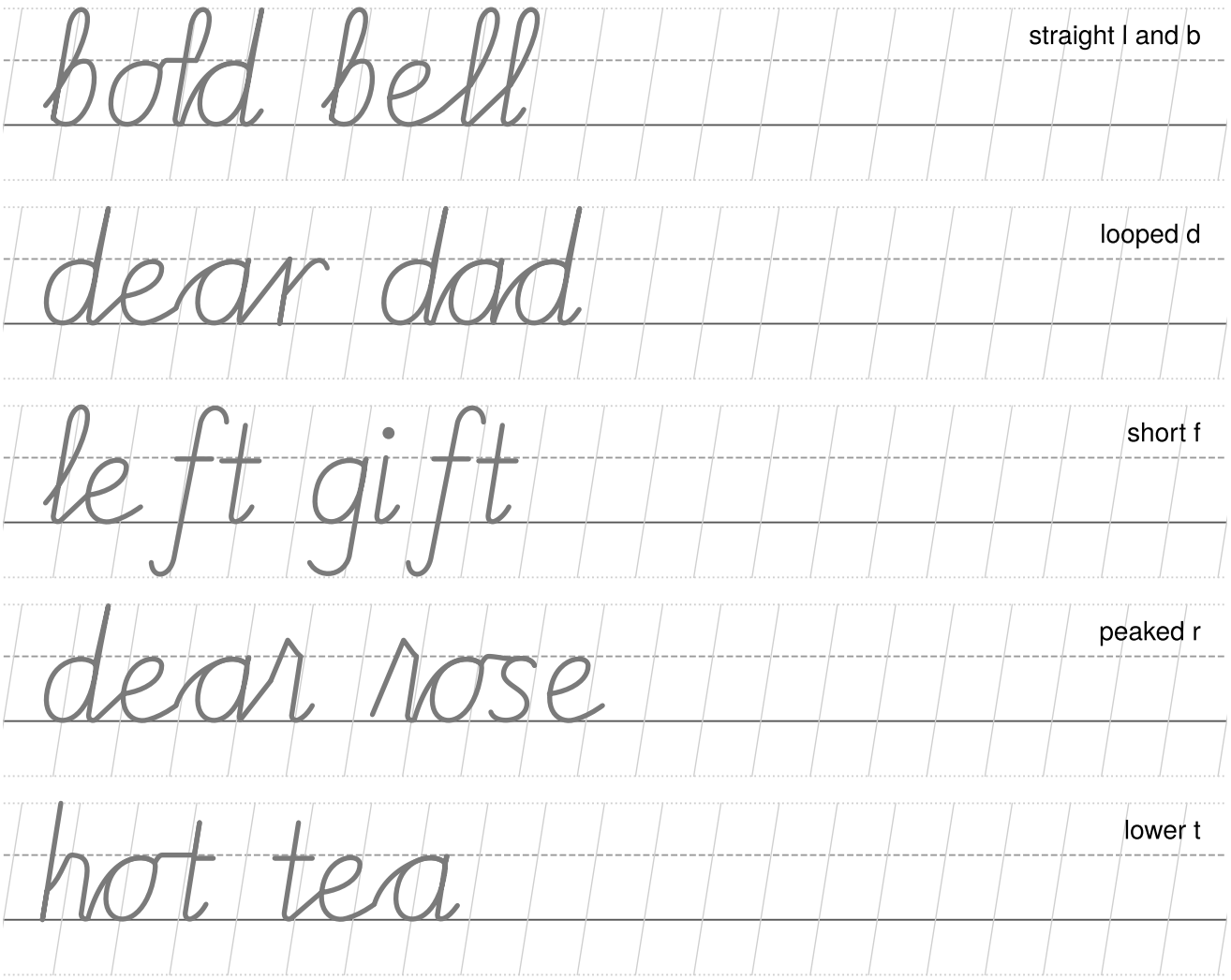
Practice: an address

Trace the grey address, then write it again on the three blank lines below, starting each line at the same left edge. Write it once more on scrap paper at envelope size, then address a real envelope to someone you plan to write to, and hold it at arm's length before you add the stamp. Stop when your hand tires; the page will wait.



Practice: your variants

Each line puts one or two variants to work. Trace the grey words, written in the Chapter 3 forms, then write the same words once in the space after them, at the same size, with the variant you are trying. Change only the letters named at the right end of the line. Skip a line whose letters you are keeping, and compare the two versions at arm's length before you decide.



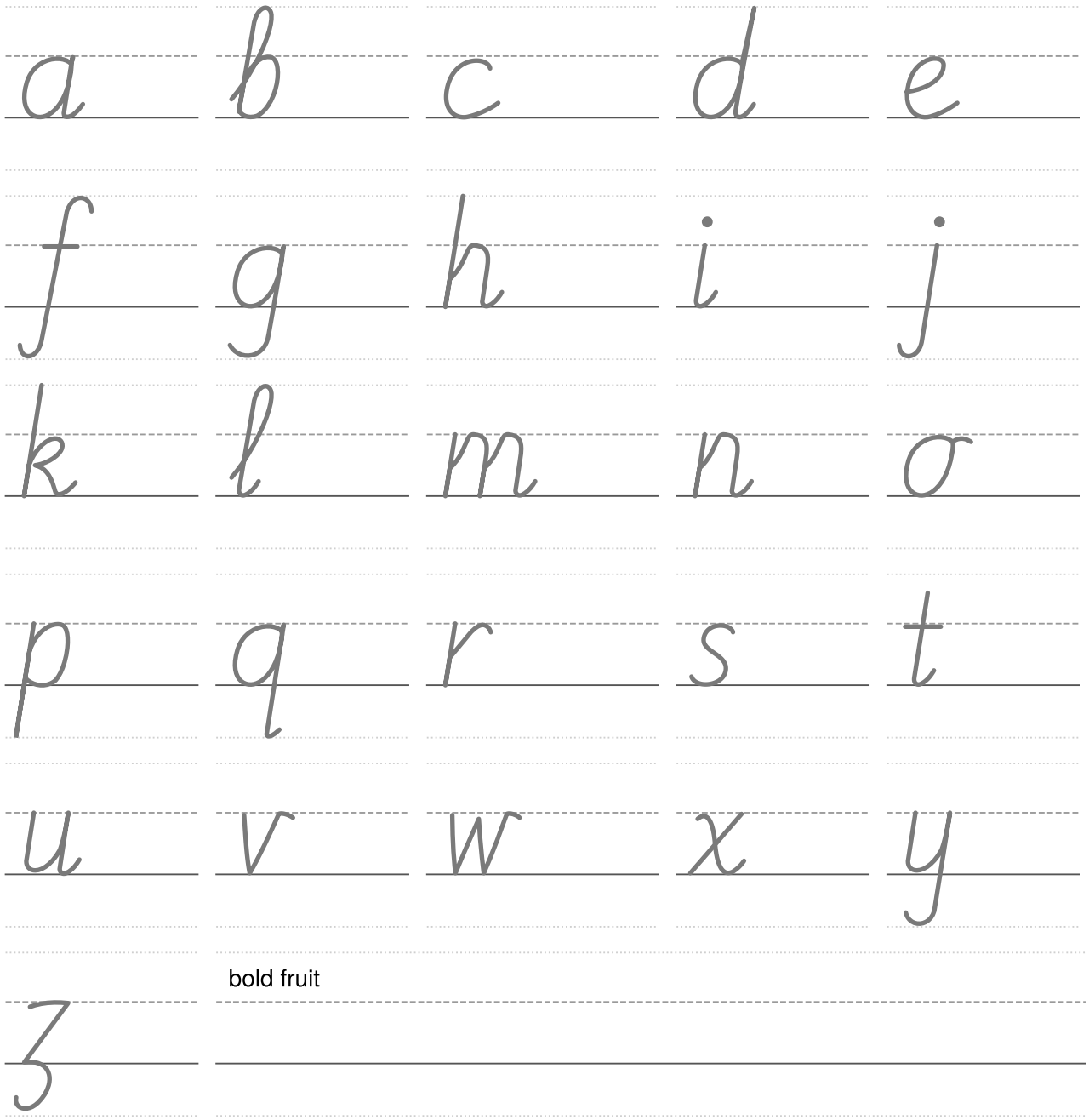
What to look at

Check the variants you chose:

- ☐ Straight stems are straight; the loop of d is narrow.
- ☐ Joins into a straight l or b run up the stem and back.
- ☐ After a short f or a peaked r, the next letter joins from the baseline.
- ☐ The r peak stands clearly above the waistline.
- ☐ Every t is the same height, shorter than l, h and k.

Your personal alphabet page

At each guide line, the grey letter is the Chapter 3 form; beside it, write the form you chose, model or variant, once, at the lean you chose. Do one row at a time, over several sittings, and rest when your hand tires. After z, write "bold fruit", which holds all six letters with variants. Keep the page as your own model.



What to look at

- ☐ Every letter has one form, used again in "bold fruit", and every downstroke leans the same way.
- ☐ l, b, d, h and k reach one height; t is shorter; tails reach one depth.
- ☐ At arm's length, every letter you changed reads at once.

Practice: the speed ladder

Climb the ladder as in "Climbing the ladder", two pages back: write the grey line once on each set, timing it, compare the lines with the table and checks on the page before this one, and use the spare set for the line that broke. Fill in one row of the log for each ladder; more ladder sheets and log rows are in the printable pack (QR code in the Introduction). Stop if your hand tires or aches; open and close it gently, as in Chapter 1, between lines.

My normal speed: _____ seconds

Model

A walk at noon.

Slow Seconds: _____

Medium Seconds: _____

Normal Seconds: _____

Again: the line that broke Speed (Slow, Medium or Normal): _____

Date	Slow (sec)	Medium (sec)	Normal (sec)	What broke first

Practice: from ruled lines to blank paper

Everything on this page is at everyday size. In block 1, take your normal speed again at this size on scrap paper, then climb the ladder with the grey line, once per ruled line, and log the times on the ladder page, with "everyday" beside the date. In block 2, make a pencil dot where the grey line would end, level with your start, and write toward it. In block 3, time the note on scrap paper at your normal pace, then write it on the card taking about half as long again, with your own line breaks and a light pencil baseline for each line. Stop if your hand tires or aches.

1 Everyday-size ladder

A walk at noon.

Slow ____ sec

Medium ____ sec

Normal ____ sec

2 No lines

The plumber comes on Thursday at nine.

3 On a card

Dear Ellen, congratulations on your retirement. Lunch is on me next Friday. Warmly, Ruth

Practice: faux calligraphy

Use the pen you write with every day. Do one row, then rest your hand; if it aches, stop for the day. Rows 5 and 6 can wait for another sitting.

- **Row 1:** trace the grey word welcome, then the dashed lines, then fill the space between each dashed line and its letter.
- **Row 2:** write welcome once yourself and thicken it.
- **Row 3:** trace the grey words thank you, then add the second lines yourself and fill them in. The downstrokes are the stems of t, h, a, n and k, the right legs of h, n and k, both stems of u, the left sides of a and o, and both downstrokes of y.
- **Row 4:** write thank you yourself and thicken it.
- **Rows 5 and 6:** write a name you often put on cards, capital included, plain on row 5 and thickened on row 6. Trace the capital in the air first, as in step 2, to find its downstrokes.



Your two hands side by side

Set the page from "Try it now" beside Figure 8.2, which shows the word welcome twice, at the same size and on the same guide lines: in your everyday hand, and in the display hand of the brush pen.

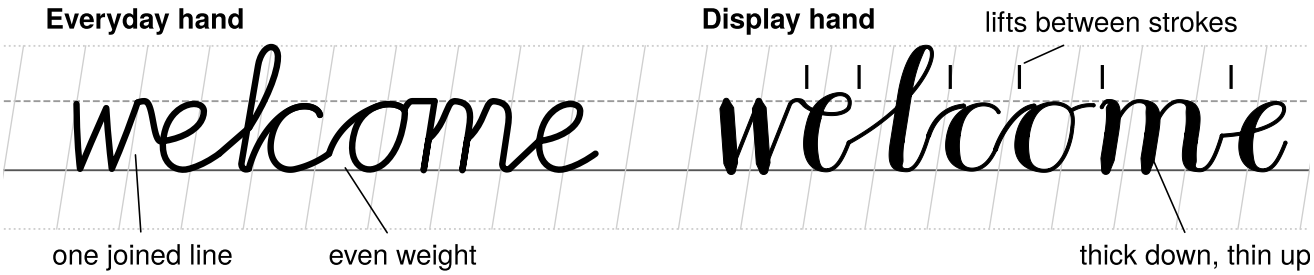


Figure 8.2 The same word in your everyday hand and in your display hand: same shapes, same slant, a different line.

The shapes, the height and the slant stay the same; what changed is the line itself, as the labels show. Your faux calligraphy sits between the two: the look of the brush word, drawn on top of your everyday one, with the thickness added after writing instead of pressed in as you go.

Practice: your word in both hands

Choose a word you like to write, perhaps a name for a card. Write it in your everyday hand on row 1 and in faux calligraphy on row 2, check row 2 against the faux calligraphy "What to look at", and date the page. Row 3 waits for the same word written with the brush pen, once you can form its letters.

Everyday hand

Faux calligraphy

Brush pen

What to look at

Check your drills:

- ☐ The ladder grows step by step, with no sudden jump in width.
- ☐ In the zigzag, every upstroke is thin and every downstroke thick.
- ☐ The ramps widen and narrow smoothly, with no blot where the pressure changes.
- ☐ The thick side of each oval is on the left.

Practice: the pressure drills

Trace each grey drill slowly, then repeat it on the rest of the line. One page is enough for a sitting. Rest your hand between rows, and stop for the day when your lines get shaky from tiredness.

Ladder



Zigzag



Ramps



Pressure ovals



If pressing keeps hurting, or your hand shakes even with a light hold, talk to your doctor or ask to see an occupational therapist. An occupational therapist can suggest grips and tools for your hands; nothing in this book takes the place of that advice.

Practice: the first four strokes

Trace the grey strokes, then write your own on the rest of the line and on the empty lines at the bottom. Say the pressure to yourself as you go: light, press, ease off. One page is enough for a sitting; rest your hand between rows, and stop for the day when your lines get shaky from tiredness.

Upstroke



Downstroke



Overturn



Underturn



Practice: curves, ovals and loops

Trace the grey strokes, then write your own on the rest of the line and on the empty lines at the bottom. Expect the loops to wobble at first; take them slowly. One page is enough for a sitting; rest your hand between rows, and stop for the day when your lines get shaky from tiredness.

Compound curve



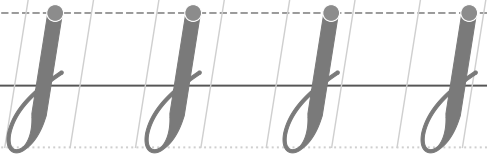
Oval



Ascending loop



Descending loop



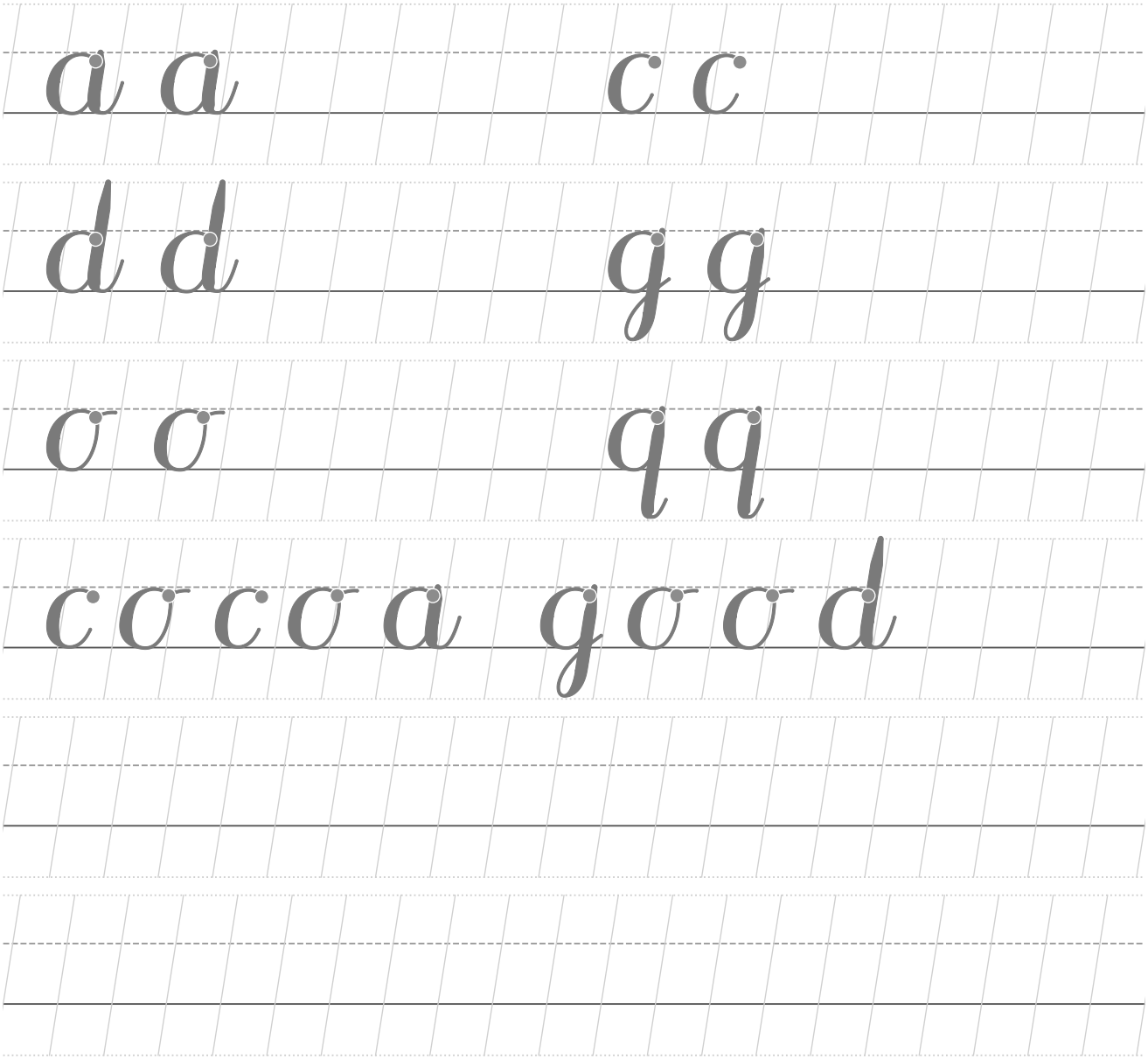
What to look at

Check your oval letters as you go:

- ☐ Every oval is thick on the left and closes in a thin join near the top.
- ☐ The stems of a, d, g and q touch the oval, with no gap.
- ☐ The stems run parallel to the slant lines.
- ☐ The tail of g is a narrow loop that crosses the stem at the baseline.

Practice: the oval family

Trace the grey models stroke by stroke, lifting where Figure 10.2 on the facing page shows, then fill the rest of each half row with your own. On row 4, trace the words, then write them again on rows 5 and 6 with the letters apart. One or two rows are a full session. Stop when your hand tires; the page waits.



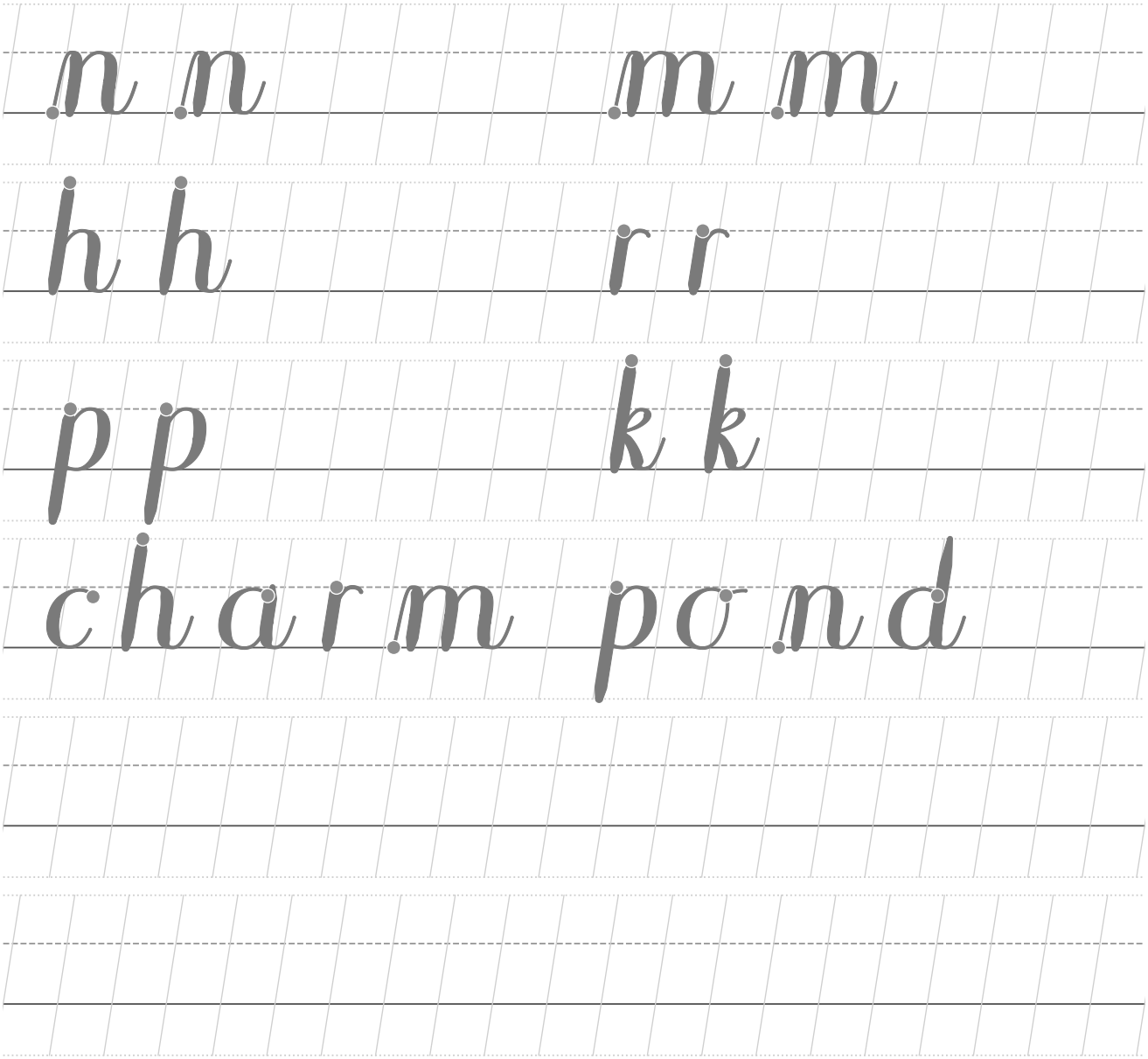
What to look at

Check your hill letters as you go:

- ☐ Each arch starts on the stem at half height, with no gap.
- ☐ The tops of the arches and bowls are thin and round.
- ☐ The two arches of m are the same width.
- ☐ The shoulder of r stays thin and stops at the waistline.

Practice: the hill family

Trace the grey models stroke by stroke, lifting where the figure on the facing page shows, then fill the rest of each half row. On row 4, trace the words, then write them again on rows 5 and 6 with the letters apart. One or two rows are a full session; rest your hand between rows.



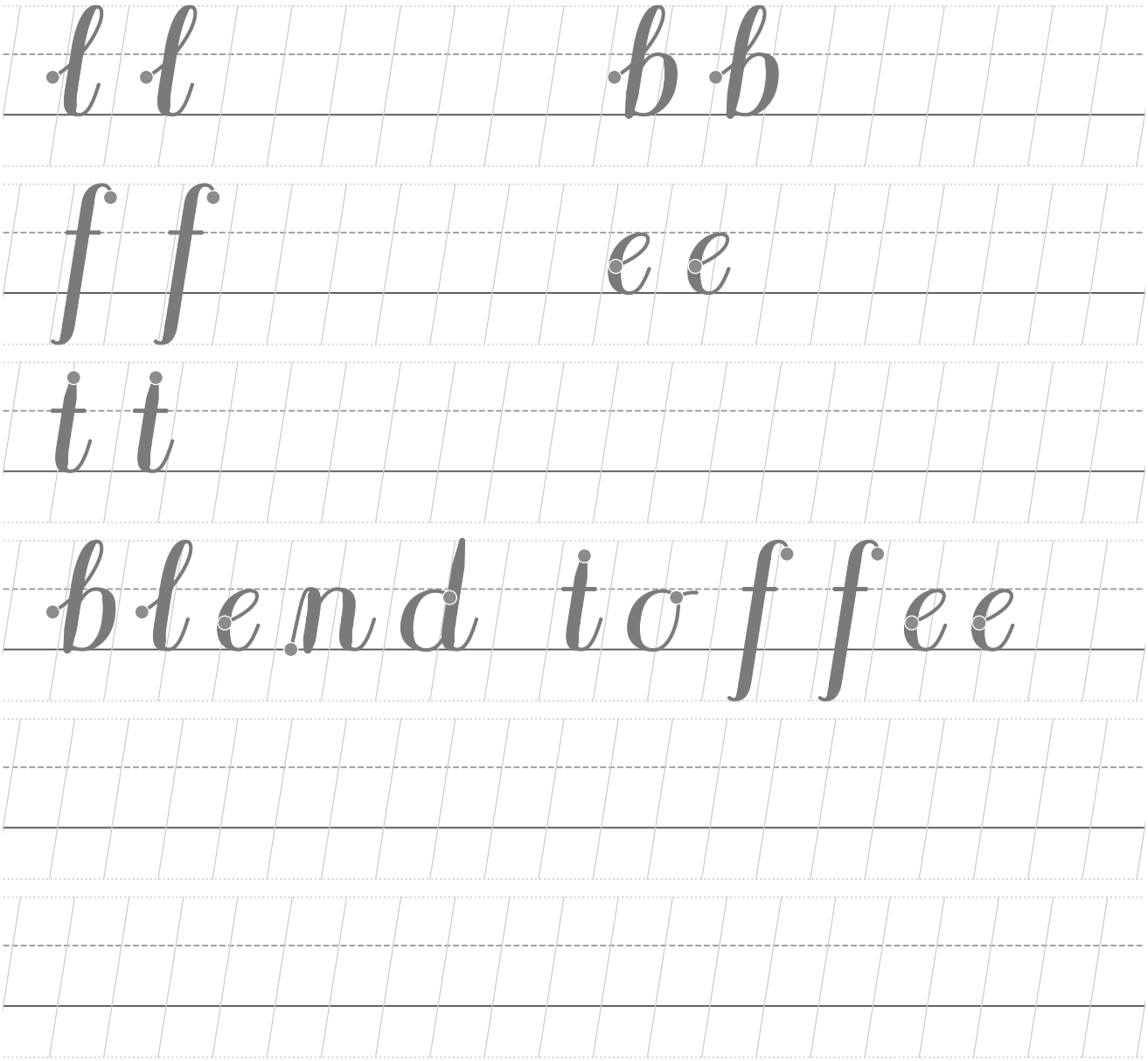
What to look at

Check your loop letters as you go:

- ☐ The loops of l and b are narrow and reach the top line.
- ☐ The loop of e is small, open and thin at the top.
- ☐ The crossbars of f and t are hairlines on the waistline.
- ☐ The stem of f is straight and reaches the tail line.

Practice: the loop family

Trace the grey models stroke by stroke, lifting where the figure on the facing page shows, then fill the rest of each half row; on row 3, fill the whole row with t. On row 4, trace the words, then write them again on rows 5 and 6 with the letters apart. One or two rows are a full session; rest your hand between rows.
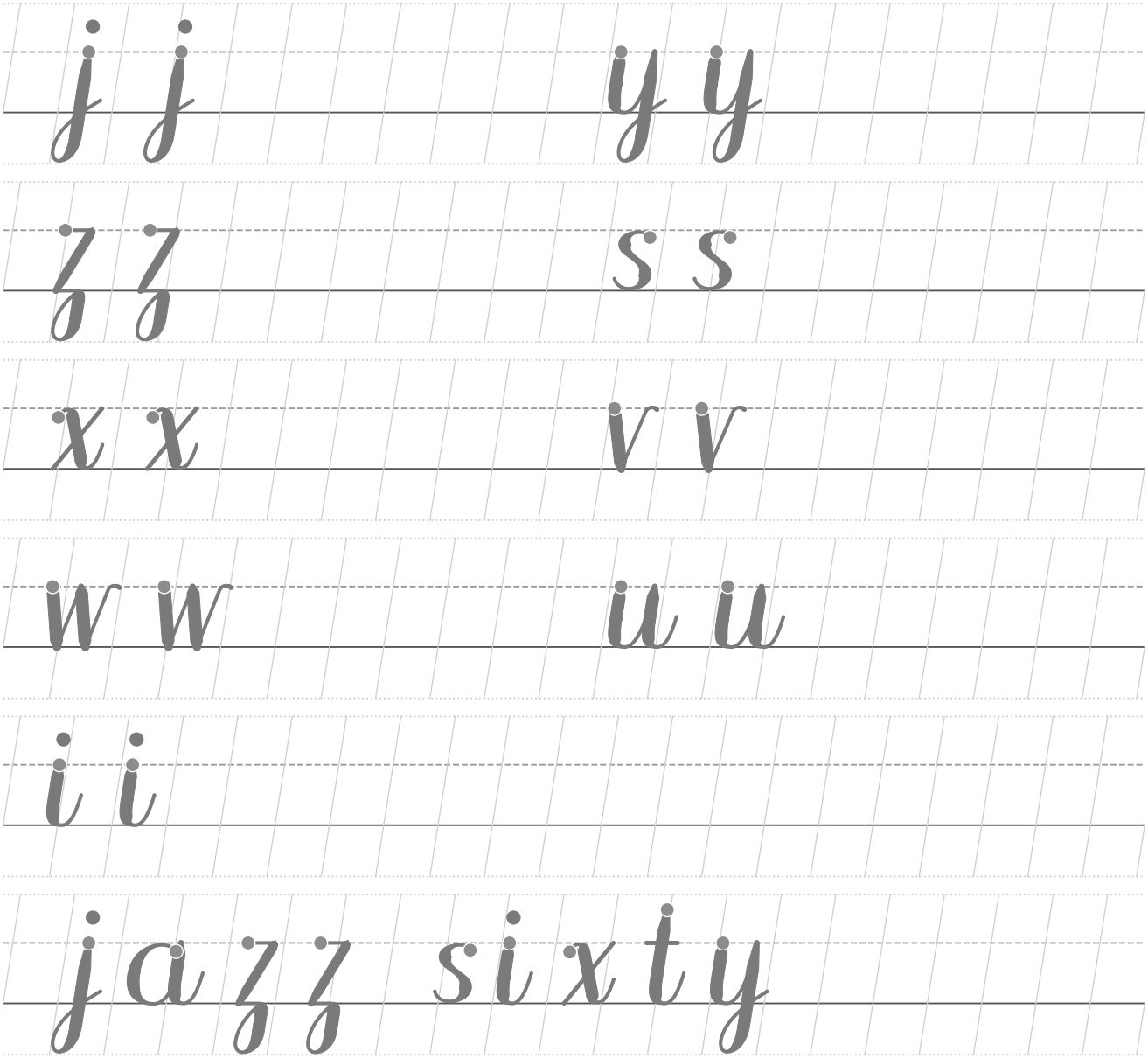


What to look at

Check your tails and troublemakers as you go:

- ☐ Each tail is a narrow loop that crosses at the baseline (z: returns to the end of its foot) and stops just above it.
- ☐ The dots are small and round, right above the stem.
- ☐ The s is narrow, thick only through the middle.
- ☐ v and w have sharp points; u is round at the bottom.

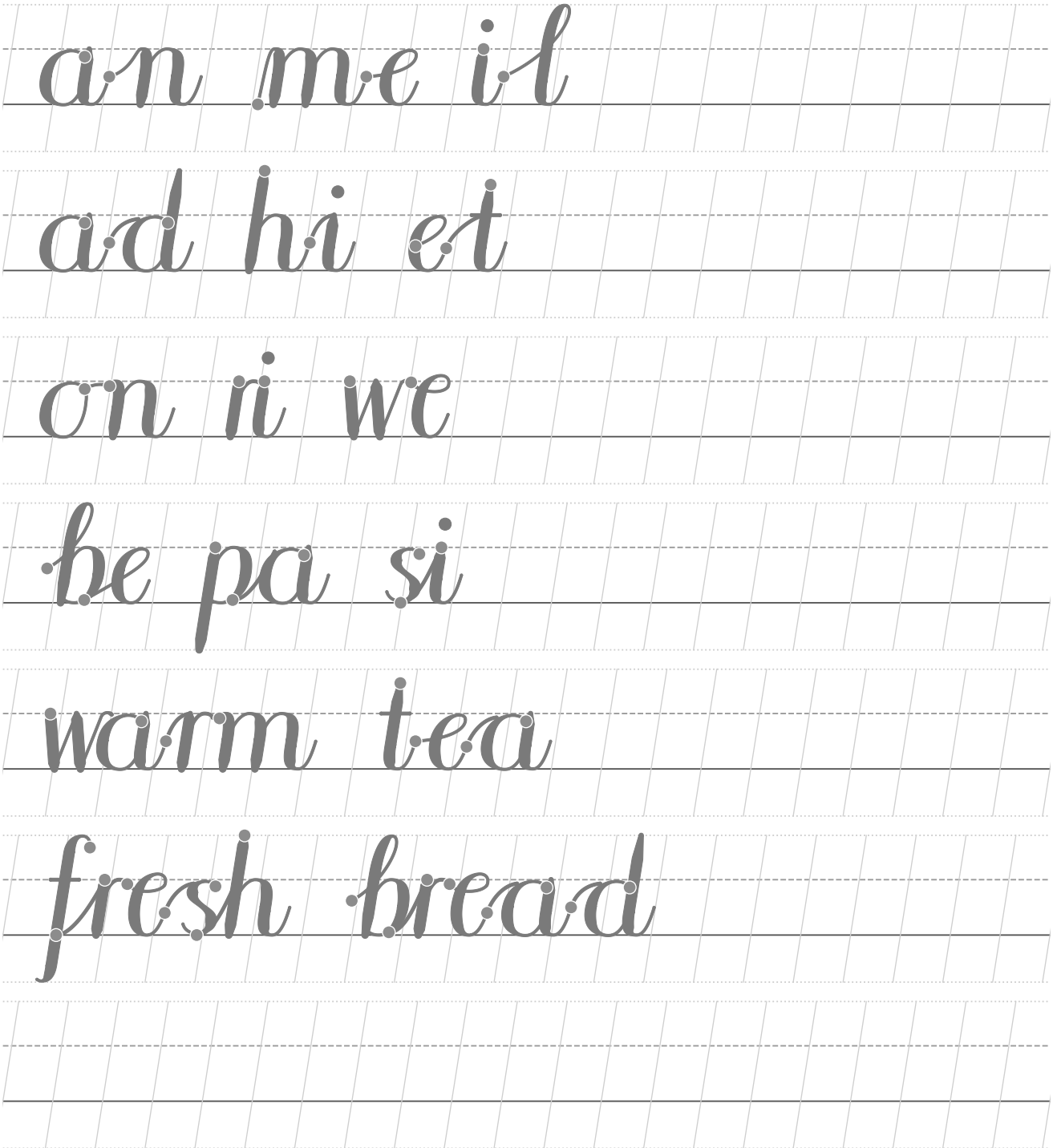
Practice: tails and troublemakers

Trace the grey models stroke by stroke, lifting where the figure on the facing page shows, then fill the rest of each half row. On row 6, trace the words, letters apart; write jazz again on the blank part of row 6 and sixty on the blank half of row 5. One or two rows are a full session; rest your hand between rows.



Practice: connecting letters

Trace each grey pair, stroke by stroke, lifting after every letter, then write the pair on the rest of the row. Rows 1 to 4 follow the four rows of the table, in order. On rows 5 and 6, trace the words; write warm tea again beside its model and fresh bread on row 7. Make every connecting hairline about the same length, so the letters sit about the inside of an n apart, as in Chapter 4; round letters such as o can sit a little closer. One or two rows are a full session.



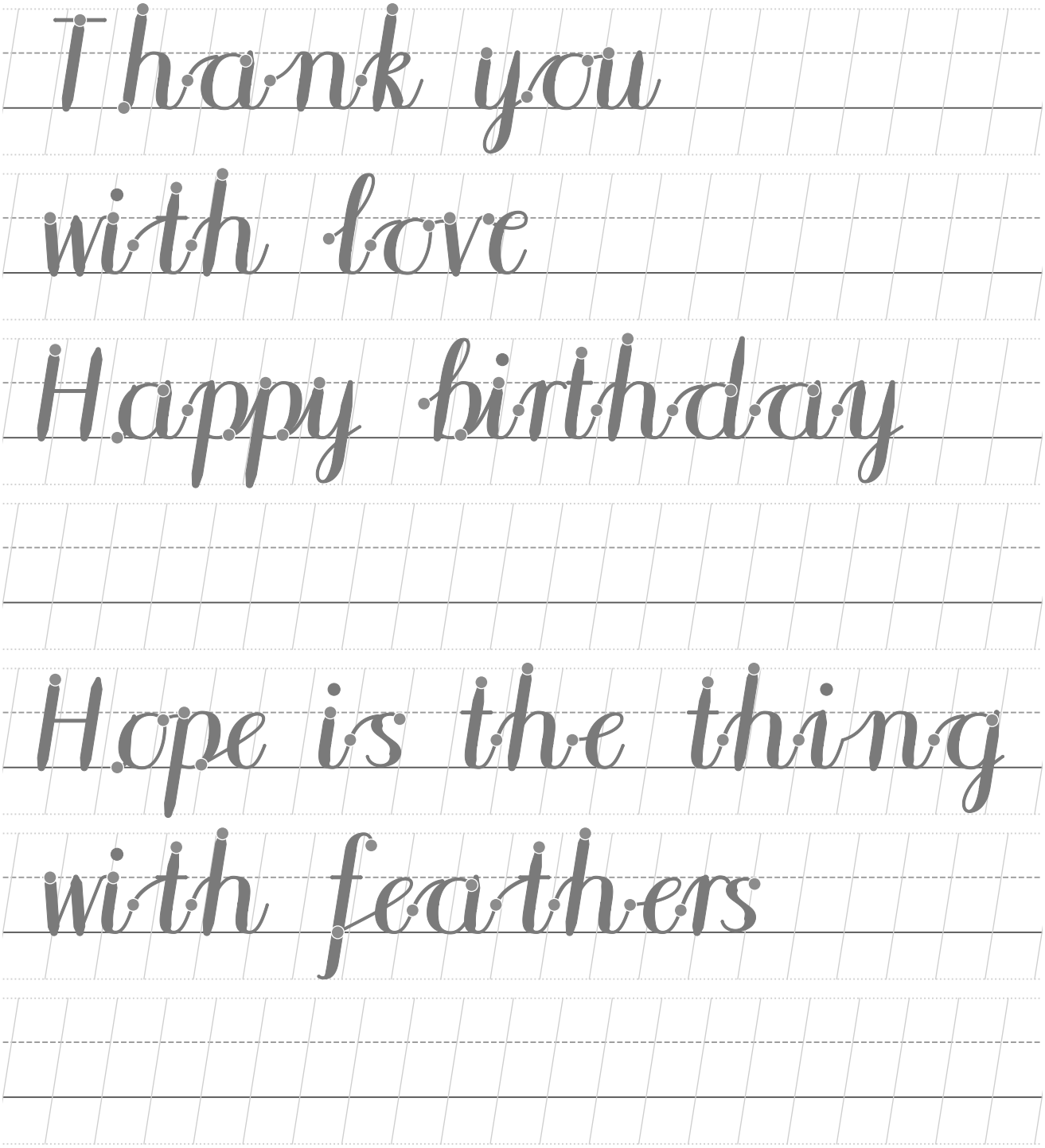
Practice: capitals and names

Trace the grey capitals stroke by stroke, lifting where Figure 10.7 shows, then the names. Lift after each capital, and start the first lowercase letter with its own hairline. On the blank rows, write the names again, or names of your own. One or two rows are a full session.



Practice: words and phrases

Trace each grey line once, slowly, lifting after every letter. Write with love again on the blank part of its row, Happy birthday on row 4 and Hope is the thing on row 7; Thank you and with feathers do not fit beside their models, so write them again on a sheet of smooth paper. Rows 5 and 6 are the opening words of a poem by Emily Dickinson. One or two rows are a full session.



Checking your work: the five things to look at

Check a finished word or line, not a single letter; these five points show across a whole word. Look at one point at a time, and when one fails, work on that one before you look at the next.

What to look at

Check your line on these five points:

- ☐ **Thick and thin:** every downstroke is thick, and every upstroke, bar and turn is a hairline, with a clear difference. If not, do a row of the pressure drills of Chapter 9 before the next word.
- ☐ **Slant:** every stem and straight downstroke runs parallel to the slant lines; the diagonals of v, w, x, z and k lean the same way each time they appear. If some lean another way, turn the paper, not your wrist. If you are left-handed and write more upright, check that all thick strokes lean the same way.
- ☐ **Spacing:** the letters sit evenly, and so do the spaces between words. If not, make the connecting hairlines the same length.
- ☐ **Size:** small letters fill the space from baseline to waistline, loops reach the top and tail lines, and capitals stop a little below the top line.
- ☐ **Connections:** each lowercase letter meets the one before at a thin join, with no gap and no blot; a capital stands apart. A gap means the pen landed short of the hairline; a blot means it landed with too much pressure.

Once your words pass this check, go back to the side-by-side page of Chapter 8 and write your word on its third row.

Practice: your own words

Write your own name on the first row, and a phrase of two or three words you would put on a card on the second. Run the five-point check on each, then write the one that needs more work again on the third row, changing one thing at a time; for more tries, use a blank guide sheet from the printable pack.



Practice: names, monograms and a card

The brush names, monograms and display words on this page are at two-thirds of practice size, the size for cards, tags and place cards. Trace each grey model slowly, lifting after every letter in the brush names and monograms, then write it again on the blank row below it. Then trace the card front: Thank you lifting after every letter, the optional everyday line with the joins of Chapter 4. Make the same card on real card stock. Stop when your hand tires; the page will wait.

Names and monograms

Grace

Thomas

RJA

RAJ

Card front

Thank you

for a lovely evening

Try the brush name at card size on these two rows before you write it on the card.

Practice: an envelope, a tag and a place card

Everything on this page is at real size. Trace each grey model in order: the return address, the brush name, the street and city lines, then the tag and the place card. Then make one of each for real, with the pencil steps of this chapter. Stop when your hand tires; the page will wait.

Envelope



Tag



Place card



Practice: a recipe card to give

Recipe cards are commonly sold at 3 by 5 and 4 by 6 inches; the card on this page is the larger size. Trace the title on row 1, then write the title of a recipe you know by heart, one or two short words, on row 2. On the card, trace the grey title and the first two lines, then add the other ingredients from Figure 11.5, or start a recipe of your own on a real card, penciled first like this one: a title baseline with a waistline 3/8 inch above it, then lines 11/32 inch apart from one left edge. Stop when your hand tires; the page will wait.



Recipe card

